Beyond the classroom. Museum Didactics and Visual Education for inclusive and participatory learning

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This paper explores the potential of museum education as a tool to promote inclusive education and teaching methodologies that integrate school learning with service to the territory, in line with the principles of Service Learning (Bornatici 2020; Cadei et al. 2021). This approach combines learning with social responsibility, enhancing direct experiences that go beyond the traditional model of the frontal lecture (Fiorin 2016). Fundamental is the use of innovative tools such as Information and Communication Technologies (ICT), virtual and augmented reality, and visual education through photography, not only as an expressive medium, but also as a research and documentation tool (Bourdieu 2018).

In an educational context profoundly transformed by social and technological changes, accentuated by the Covid-19 health emergency, and in which the importance of media literacy is increasingly emphasised, it is indeed necessary to rethink schools as nodes in a broader educational network. Museums, associations and schools thus become fundamental partners in an integrated educational system aimed at developing transversal skills and creating meaningful links between students, the territory and cultural heritage to promote meaningful learning (Zuccoli 2014).

The project starts from the awareness that the role of museums today has changed: from places of memory preservation to interdisciplinary educational spaces that foster learning beyond the classroom (Altintas et al. 2020; Branchesi et al. 2016). European and national policies have fostered this transformation, promoting the conscious use of digital resources and enhancing human capital. However, the evolution of museums as learning environments faces challenges related to accessibility and training of museum staff and teaching staff, as well as the tendency to reduce education to a mere instrument of knowledge transmission often disconnected from reality. To overcome these challenges, the project proposes a dynamic educational approach that makes students active protagonists and co-constructors of knowledge itself, in line with national and international guidelines that aim to develop in learners all those Life Skills necessary in everyday life.

Experiential and interdisciplinary learning, integrated with innovative teaching technologies, underpins this model. Visual education, in particular, is configured as a multifaceted methodology (Panciroli / Rivoltella 2021): through photography, it is possible to document the territory, stimulate critical reflection and encourage observation in the field, collecting valuable data for qualitative analysis and intervention design. By actively involving students, photography also becomes a tool to enhance cultural heritage and raise community awareness through visual narratives.

Starting from an analysis of the territory and inland areas of Southern Italy to examine the real collaboration between schools and museums, the research focuses on a central question: how can museum education, through visual education and the use of photography as a tool, foster innovative and inclusive education, promoting meaningful learning that goes beyond the confines of the traditional classroom? Starting from this question, the project intends to outline strategies and best practices for designing educational interventions that exploit museum resources and digital technologies, creating meaningful learning environments and deepening the role of museums as socio-cultural platforms capable of promoting heritage enjoyment 'in every time and place' and responding to the needs of individuals and contemporary society as a whole (Mas et al. 2021).

The analysis conducted aims to highlight how museums can tell stories that stimulate both critical thinking and emotional connection, promoting immersive and engaging experiences. Among the innovative educational tools used, digital technologies play a central role in transforming the classroom or museum galleries into a creative laboratory. Virtual and augmented reality enrich museum experiences, making them accessible to students with Special Educational Needs and beyond (Campitiello et al 2022). Photography, on the other hand, is explored for its multiple functions to develop critical and creative skills (Governa et al. 2023) and aligns with the principles of Service Learning, which encourages social responsibility and community involvement. By collaborating with museums, students can carry out

photographic projects that document local heritage and promote dialogue between school and local area (Luigini 2018).

Expected results include the creation of replicable models for inclusive educational interventions and the identification of conditions that facilitate collaboration between schools and museums. The project intends to demonstrate how the integration of museum didactics, digital technologies and participatory approaches can improve the quality of learning and foster more equitable education. In this vision, the school becomes the fulcrum of an extended educational network, with the museum as a strategic partner to address the challenges of contemporary society and promote inclusive, experiential and closely related learning.

The integration of visual education stimulates participative and reflective learning: students develop visual awareness, a deeper understanding of cultural heritage and transversal skills such as creativity, attention to detail and narrative ability. This approach strengthens emotional involvement and transforms museums into dynamic and accessible spaces for all.

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